

The Years in a Second

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Third Draft

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The sound of a pocket watch crown being pulled out.

TIM (V.O.)
And behind those golden wrinkles, I
still see the beautiful woman I fell
in love with...

INT./EXT. HOSPITAL ROOM - DAY, 2045

A pocket watch inside a man's right hand. His left hand's fingers are slowly winding the pocket watch. There are faint sounds of the inner gears turning.

TIM (28) is standing just outside the room. He let's go of the crown, leaving it pulled out. He looks inside the room.

An old woman with gray hair, MILIA, lying in a hospital bed, wrinkly and fatigued.

TIM (V.O.)
...a lifetime ago.

She's talking to a couple in their late 50s. Next to the couple stand a boy (13) and a girl (10). The family is surrounding her, their backs facing Tim, and sharing teary smiles.

Not like Tim wants any attention. He's only focusing on Milia, peripheral, lost in memories.

His thumb is firmly placed above the watch's crown.

NURSE (O.S.)
Excuse me, sir. You're in the way.

Tim snaps out of his gaze.

A nurse with a clipboard is standing next to him with a begging look on her face.

TIM
Oh, I'm- I was just about to leave.

The nurse enters the room, drawing attention to her.

NURSE
Your results are in, Ms. Emerson.

As the nurse talks, Milia's attention wanders from her to the doorway. There's a click.

Her angle reveals Tim isn't there anymore. We focus on Milia as the nurse keeps talking.

NURSE (cont'd)
...and while vitals do look stable,
we'll have to keep you in for
monitoring. Another day or two.

MATCH CUT TO:

EXT. UNIVERSITY - PHYSICS HALL - DAY, 2025

Milia (27) standing in front of the Physics Hall, holding a notebook together with a book about general relativity.

She's talking to the classmates surrounding her. Her hair is bright red. The type of beauty that naturally draws in crowds. The only wrinkles on her face are the crow's feet she has from smiling and laughing.

Tim, here also 27, is walking towards the building's entrance. He's looking at Milia with infatuated eyes.

They don't know each other yet.

He knows he won't walk up to her, despite the urge to do so.

Instead, he gets out a POCKET WATCH, looks at the time, and hurries inside.

Pull in closer to Milia and her gang.

MILIA
I don't know if I'd want a boyfriend
anytime soon. Maybe if it's the right
guy at the exact right time. But
during my doctorate?

FEMALE CLASSMATE #1
So real. I broke up with mine last
month because of this.

MALE CLASSMATE #1
That's the worst. For both of you.

FEMALE CLASSMATE #1
It is. I miss him.

MALE CLASSMATE #1
But then, who knows. What if you two
meet again, different circumstances.

FEMALE CLASSMATE #2
Maybe he was the wrong guy.

FEMALE CLASSMATE #1
Right person, wrong time. Wasn't
there a study on that?

Some are looking at Milia, implying she'd know the answer.

MILIA
Oh, I don't know if there's any
research done on that. But I'd say
it's almost impossible to tell.

MALE CLASSMATE #2
So you don't believe in true love?

FEMALE CLASSMATE #1
She barely wants a boyfriend, I doubt
she's thinking about love.

MILIA
Plus, there's the whole...

MALE CLASSMATE #1
It's either the right person or not.
What else could there be?

MILIA
Just thinking, what if your soulmate
isn't born when you're alive?

FEMALE CLASSMATE #2
Then true love is fucked.

We see the group through the window of the Physics Hall.
Male Classmate #1 checks his phone, like he just remembered
something. He taps Female Classmate #2 on the shoulder.

They walk off together, he puts his arm around her. the
group slowly dissolves.

Milia waves everyone goodbye and heads for the Physics Hall.

INT. PHYSICS LAB 325 - DAY

Tim balances in a chair on its two back legs. He could fall
at any moment, but looks like he's in control.

Across from him sits BENICIO (28) ramrod straight while
facing his computer. He's wearing a white lab coat over a
button-down. The coat is spotless and purely for fashion.

He spins around in his chair holding a pocket watch out like
he's proposing.

BENICIO

They bought all of our research.
Financing the rest of our studies.
We'll be drowning in cash, Tim. I
mean, which one of us noticed those
abnormal readings from Vanadium?

TIM

That was you.

BENICIO

Right. You're right. But you were the
one who chose Vanadium to begin with.

TIM

No, that was also you. I wanted to
take a closer look at Palladium and
Zirconium because both are already
used in watchmaking. Palladium wasn't
in our budget-

BENICIO

(cuts him off)

And Zirconium ended up being useless.

Tim takes a closer look at his pocket watch.

TIM

I knew it would be. But this piece is
partly made of Zirconium. Called
ceramic if you're a watchmaker. So I
wanted to see if there's any hope in
making it work for the project.

BENICIO

Can you believe how cheap Vanadium
is? It's the perfect metal if we want
to have this thing take off.

TIM

You really want a generation of
unregulated time travelers? Our
current model doesn't have a proper
preflight system yet.

Tim keeps tinkering the watch. He turns it over in his
hands. Opens the case. Closes it. Studying the movement.

BENICIO

The preflight blows our scope.

TIM

Without a preflight, this thing here
might blow us to bits.

Benicio lays his watch down on the table. He leans back, hands behind his head, feet up on the desk right next to the watch. The lab coat rides up.

BENICIO

They can have the lawsuits. I just want a nice profit percentage.

TIM

You think you'll see the money Equinox makes off of this?

BENICIO

As long as we sell the rights and not the knowledge. Secure employment.

TIM

You aren't nervous?

BENICIO

Don't have to be.

Tim looks at the watch on Benicio's desk. Not a word.

INT. EQUINOX INC. - BOARDROOM - DAY

Tim and Benicio - in suits - standing in front of a stern looking board of executives twice their age. Behind them, a whiteboard covered in formulas and arc diagrams. It looks impressive and complicated. It's meant to.

Both Tim and Benicio are nervous, but Benicio is better at hiding it.

BENICIO

Perfect. If there's nothing else, We'll go over the theoretical details. Tim.

Tim begins drawing on the whiteboard.

TIM

First, let's look at what time itself is. *Sounds* easy, given we're human. For scientific purposes, let's assume time is the potential difference between two instances of existence.

BENICIO

(whispering)
You're losing them.

Tim freezes. Then erases part of the whiteboard and sketches multiple arcs jumping closer and closer to the center.

TIM

If a person travels a year into the future, what happens to him the second after he leaves? He's not there. So universally speaking, for one year, we're in a deficit of matter. However, we can take advantage of that.

EXECUTIVE

How exactly would you do that?

BENICIO

You probably know this from movies, time travel paradoxes. You meet yourself, the whole world explodes.

TIM

But traveling within a gap, avoiding any matter surplus, instead going with a deficit, that allows for time travel that's safe for the public.

EXECUTIVE

Okay, hold on. I'm not a, sorry, doctorate in quantum mechanics, but why is a surplus, the same person twice, causing a paradox whereas a deficit is perfectly fine.

BENICIO

Great question. The answer is: we don't know. So we're researching it.

TIM

It's what our thesis revolves around.

There's a tense pause followed by murmurs.

BOARD MEMBER

(to Executive)

I don't know. It's high risk.

The executive waves to tell the others to lower their voices. Tim and Benicio are sweating.

EXECUTIVE

The only question left is would there be any legal limitations in our way? We're talking about human test subjects, after all.

Tim and Benicio stare blankly through the committee.

INT. UNIVERSITY - ETHICS COMMITTEE - FLASHBACK

Tim and Benicio talking to BEATRIX, the 50-year-old ethics coordinator.

Her desk is covered in binders and books.

Beatrice looks less than amused thanks to her natural resting-bitch face.

BEATRIX
Time travel?

TIM
Yes, ma-am.

Beatrice glances up for a second.

BENICIO
I already checked every ethics guideline and framework available through the university and National Science Foundation. We're clear.

Beatrice looks at Benicio like he wasn't supposed to speak.

BEATRIX
You're clear because there are no guidelines for time travel. However, if what you're saying were true, there are reasonable concerns whether you're allowed to physically displace human beings to another time.

BENICIO
You wouldn't even know they're gone. They'd be back the next second.

BEATRIX
Then why bother asking? Sweep it under the rug.

BENICIO
(taps on a binder)
We have to. Says so in here. Otherwise this ends up on page forty of this thing.

INT. EQUINOX INC. - BOARDROOM - CONTINUOUS

BENICIO

There are none to speak of. Our research sits in a regulatory gap due to its relative novelty.

The executive glances down the table.

Beat.

EXECUTIVE

Gentlemen, let's get to work.

Benicio has never looked happier. Tim looks relieved.

INT. EQUINOX INC. HALLWAY, 2025

Tim and Benicio heading for the lobby.

TIM

Why did you lie to their faces?

BENICIO

Because we need this.

TIM

What if they find out about the new regulations.

BENICIO

There's no way to enforce them. It'll be us traveling through time anyway, and you know how it works, it's a seamless transition. Like never being gone at all.

TIM

Right, but we don't know the effect time travel has on our bodies.

BENICIO

And we won't know until after we get funded. It's a Catch-22.

TIM

It's not. Have you read the book?

BENICIO

Let's not argue. Celebrate.

INT. PHYSICS LAB 325 - DAY

Tim tweaking around on the pocket watch.

The face looks normal. Second, minute and hour clock. The three sub-dials display day, month and year. There's also a small display that reads:

04/12/2028 16:34:13

The seconds tick.

Benicio walks into the lab with a half eaten sandwich.

TIM

Check it out, Benny. The preflight system works. No more manual entering dates going by seconds. It just detects whether the time you're attempting to travel to is valid.

BENICIO

Thank god. Those numbers were getting too big to comprehend. I remember checking last Tuesday, 290072143 was the number of seconds until midnight on my birthday.

TIM

Eleven months, roundabout?

BENICIO

That or 337 days.

TIM

You better put that prototype away.

BENICIO

(waving prototype)

What? This is still genius.

TIM

Dangerous.

BENICIO

Perfectly fine in capable hands.

TIM

One second off and you're dead.

BENICIO

Alright, alright. I'll stow it away.

Benicio opens his drawer and puts the watch inside.

BENICIO (cont'd)

Happy?

Tim doesn't answer. Goes back to the watch.

INT. ART GALLERY - DAY

Tim is gazing at a painting of a mother holding her child.

Stylistically, the painting lies somewhere between Edward Hopper and Norman Rockwell.

Tim stares longer than he needs to, like he's recalling that moment of his life, when he was held like that as well.

JON (O.S.)

Beautiful, right?

Tim's friend JON materializes at his shoulder. Tim doesn't flinch. He's used to this.

They look at the painting together.

TIM

She's very pretty.

JON

Not the woman, the painting.

TIM

Those aren't the same thing?

JON

This isn't a portrait. The woman doesn't exist. Never has. So who do you think is pretty?

TIM

This is why I'm a STEM major and not an art guy like you.

JON

Even scientists are just glorified philosophers. But I'm just kidding, Tim. It's my favorite, as well.

TIM

It's like I'm the baby. How long did this one take you?

JON

Two months.

TIM

I'll never get how you artists create these things in such little time.

JON

Half that time was me staring at a blank canvas, mind you.

TIM

I haven't seen the whole gallery yet.

JON

Oh, take your time, Tim. These all have the same theme.

TIM

Which is?

JON

Stare at it a little longer, you'll find out.

A girly laugh catches Tim's attention.

A very pretty college student is giggling away next to a guy that could only be considered her boyfriend. She's holding her belly and pushing her lover to the side.

Jon notices where Tim's gaze went.

JON (cont'd)

There's something inherently depressing about seeing a cute girl laugh wholeheartedly while knowing you'll never be the reason she'd feel that way.

TIM

Where did you get that from?
Girlfriend dump you?

Jon doesn't say anything.

TIM (cont'd)

(shocked)

No. Grace dumped you?

JON

She will. Maybe in a week. Right after the show. It's alright, though. Guess it was a six month fling. Better than having her pack her things years down the line.

TIM

Can I do anything for you?

JON

I'm seriously alright, thanks. This is my fault anyway. I poured my heart into my paintings when she was waiting for a drop of affection.

TIM

You're a good dude, don't beat yourself up like that.

JON

I'd cheer up over a round of beers.

TIM

My treat.

JON

Back to us both being single.

TIM

I was already.

JON

There's an art faculty thing next week, but a couple science majors will be there. Grace mentioned her friend's study group might come.

Jon trails off to study the painting.

Tim waits for an explanation.

JON (cont'd)

The red-haired Physics beauty. The one you can't even name.

TIM

You're just saying things.

JON

Oh, you know who I'm talking about.

Beat. Both their eyes glued to the painting.

JON (cont'd)

Her name is Milia. Saturday.

CUT TO: